journalism, a fellow crime reporter suggested I was writing fiction, a leading politician from Tamil Nadu labelled me anti-Tamil and the LTTE supremo called me an agent of the CBI in his interview to the Western media. A former Prime Minister called my editor and asked if the story of the dry run conducted in his political rally in Tamil Nadu was true. An official from 10 Janpath asked if I could share my stories with Rajiv's family before they were published. Even the SIT boss called parts of my story figments of my imagination. But he had no explanation to offer when three well-known people, who were named in the story, were arrested by the same SIT. The celebrated journalist from the southern daily, too, kept quiet, failing to substantiate his charges. Understandably, my editor-in-chief was concerned. He tapped his own sources in the government and was told that every story published by the magazine was factually correct, thus adding to my motivation to keep chasing the bigger story.

But then the threats started coming in from other quarters. Suspicious characters would follow my car in Madras, call my hotel room and not speak or leave a note under my door telling me not to visit Jaffna in Sri Lanka. It's another matter that I was not granted a visa to visit Jaffna, but an incident that soon followed shocked me.

The chief metropolitan magistrate (CMM) was hearing the application of the police remand of the accused, including key conspirators Nalini, Murugan, Peraribalan and Robert Payas. The investigating officer (IO) of the case, K. Ragothaman, was standing between Murugan in handcuffs and me. The CMM had asked something and Ragothaman had stepped forward to answer. Murugan turned, gave me a cold stare and said something in Tamil, a language not unfamiliar to me. But his accent was heavily Sinhalese. I figured he was trying to find out if I was a 'reporter'. He repeated his query to Ragothaman, who, of course, didn't pay him any attention. At the end of the hearing, someone stopped me outside the courtroom and conveyed Murugan's message to me: 'Stay away from maligning freedom fighters.' It was a cold-blooded threat, but I was told not to worry as my stories were 'getting noticed'.